4. How Early Encounters with Hostile Tribes on the Periphery Shaped China’s World View

The Chinese heartland, or what has traditionally been considered its civilizational core, is (as mentioned earlier) constituted by the alluvial plains of the Huang He and the Yangzi Jiang. This heartland expanded over time to encompass the mountainous and forested terrain towards the south and south-west as these territories were conquered, occupied and settled by the Han people from the north. This settled and largely agricultural society had borders towards its north and west consisting mainly of the arid deserts of the Tibetan highlands, the Taklamakan Desert and Tarim Basin, and the vast expanse of the steppes and grasslands of Central Asia, including Mongolia and Manchuria.

This was a hostile periphery peopled by successive waves of nomadic and semi-nomadic tribes, constantly raiding and plundering the relatively prosperous agricultural heartland and its rich and splendid cities. There were periods when parts of the heartland itself were occupied by these tribes. The Mongols and the Manchus, both powerful and aggressive steppe people, even conquered the whole of China and established their own dynasties. They would in turn have to fend off attacks from other tribes on the periphery of their empires.

In comparison with this perennial threat from the continental expanse right along its land borders, China faced relatively little threat from its equally vast maritime frontiers to the east and south, comprising the Yellow Sea, the Taiwan Strait and the South China Sea. There were occasional attacks by pirates and defiance by kingdoms in the south-east, but these were dealt with quite easily by Chinese maritime power, modest as this would have been by current standards. Thus, it is the Chinese encounters with the tribes along their land periphery which remained the main security preoccupation of successive dynasties and shaped Chinese perceptions of